

GovTech

Case Study: GoBusiness

Website UI/UX

Improvisations

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Disclaimer:

This case study is a self-initiated UX audit and redesign concept conducted independently by Karthik Manda for portfolio and learning purposes. It is not affiliated with, commissioned by, or endorsed by GoBusiness, GovTech Singapore, or the Ministry of Trade and Industry.

All findings, observations, and redesign concepts are based solely on publicly accessible interfaces and do not reflect any internal data, proprietary systems, or confidential information belonging to any government agency.

Screenshots of the GoBusiness portal are used strictly for educational and illustrative purposes to document observed usability issues. All redesign concepts are original work and represent the author's independent design perspective only.

The intent of this audit is to demonstrate applied UX skills and design thinking — not to critique the teams behind GoBusiness, who operate under constraints and considerations not visible from the public-facing interface.

GoBusiness Overview

GoBusiness is Singapore's official one-stop government platform designed to help businesses access a wide range of government e-services and resources.

Here's what it does:

Jointly developed by the Ministry of Trade and Industry (MTI), the Smart Nation and Digital Government Office (SNDGO), and GovTech, it offers personalized help and recommendations for businesses through its e-Advisers.

Key features include:

- **Licenses & Permits** — A simplified one-stop application gateway covering over 220 business licenses across 29 government agencies.
- **Government e-Services** — Over 300 government e-services are accessible through a directory, making searches quick and simple.
- **e-Advisers & Guided Journeys** — Access to personalized recommendations from over 200 e-Advisers on various business needs, helping users navigate operational aspects from event organization to skills training. [GovTech](#)
- **Grants & Assistance** — Easy access to over 100 government assistance schemes, including tax incentives, loans, grants, toolkits and programs.
- **Business Registration** — Prospective entrepreneurs can check business name availability and access ACRA's BizFile + portal through the platform to complete formal registration.

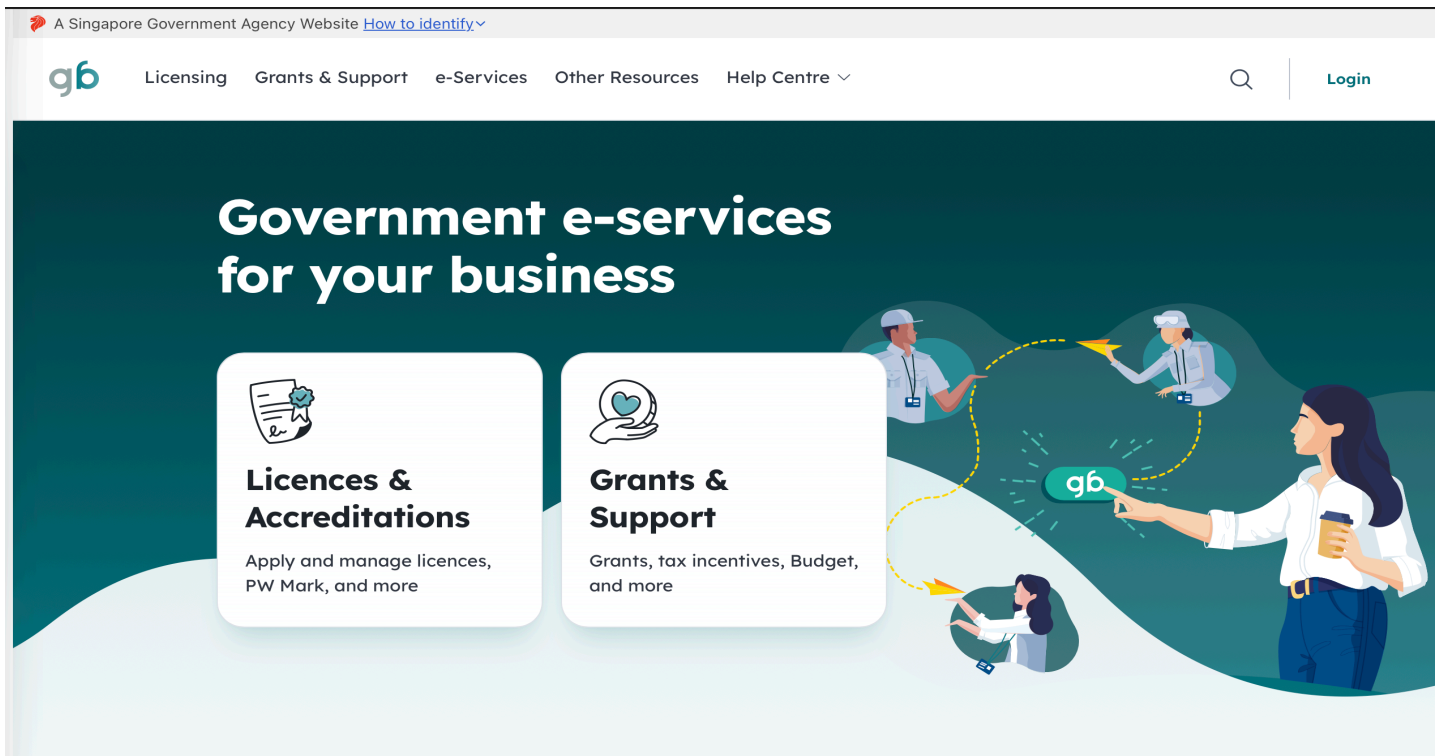


Figure 1 – (Homepage for the current GoBusiness Website).

About Case Study

Despite its scale, several usability gaps in GoBusiness create friction for the business it serves. As part of a self-initiated UX audit, I conducted a structured heuristic evaluation of the portal. Examining navigation, information architecture and hierarchy, accessibility, the logged-in dashboard experience, and feedback mechanisms. The goal was not to critique for its own sake, but to identify where design improvements would have the most meaningful impact on real users.

This Case study documents 7 findings from that audit, under Nielsen's usability heuristics and prioritized by severity. I developed redesign concepts showing how the experience can be improved with annotations explaining reasoning behind each decision.

Audit Methodology

I evaluated GoBusiness using Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics as a structured framework. This approach allows findings to be

communicated clearly to both design and non-design stakeholders and enables consistent severity scoring across issues.

Each finding was assigned a severity rating:

Critical – Blocks task completion or causes significant user error. MUST BE FIXED.

Major – Creates significant friction or confusion. High priority to address.

Minor – Reduces efficiency or polish. Should be addressed when possible.

Heuristic Evaluation

2 critical findings and 1 major finding and 4 minor finding were identified.

#	Findings	Heuristic	Severity
1.	No dropdown menus for navigation categories	Recognition over recall	Critical
2.	No dark mode/ system preference support	Accessibility & inclusive design.	Minor
3.	No language options for non-English users	Accessibility & inclusive design.	Major
4.	GoBiz chat minimize window option	Error prevention	Minor
5.	Login page has no back navigation option	User control & freedom	Critical
6.	No alphabetical index between sub-topics	Aesthetic & Minimalist design	Minor
7.	Dashboard lacks hover states, recommendations & drop-down menus.	Aesthetic & minimalist design	Minor

Findings in Detail

Each finding follows the same structure: what I observed, why it's a problem for the user → the heuristic it violates. Screenshots from GoBusiness website are included as evidence.

Finding 1 → No Dropdown Navigation – Critical

Problem: The top navigation bar presents all categories as flat, peer-level systems with no grouping or hierarchy. Users must read every label and open the section to access the subtopics and there is no way to preview sub-categories without clicking through and saves user's time and enhances experience.

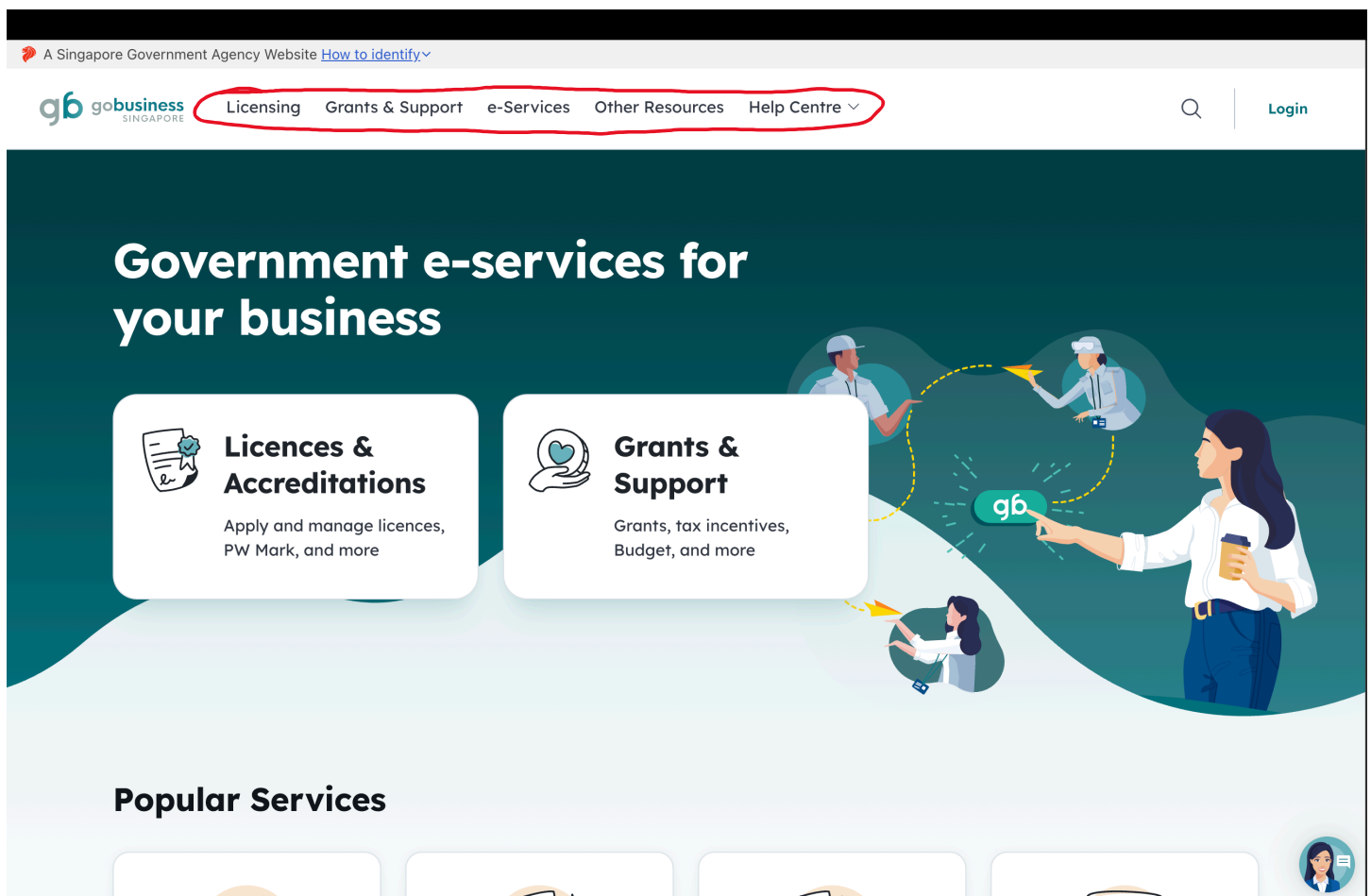


Figure 2 - (Current structure highlighted in red outline)

Why is this a problem: Without grouping or dropdowns, users will have to rely on memory to know where the feature lives. This violates the “Recognition over Recall” heuristic. Users should not have to remember information from one part of the interface to another. For infrequent users specially, this creates confusion and increases the time-on-task significantly.

Impact: GoBusiness users are infrequent visitors. Without navigational hierarchy, every session starts with a scanning exercise rather than a direct path to the task.

Finding 2 → No Dark Mode or System Preference Support – Minor

Problem: GoBusiness only renders in light mode regardless of the user’s operating system or browser preference. Users who have set their device into dark mode get no experience on the portal.

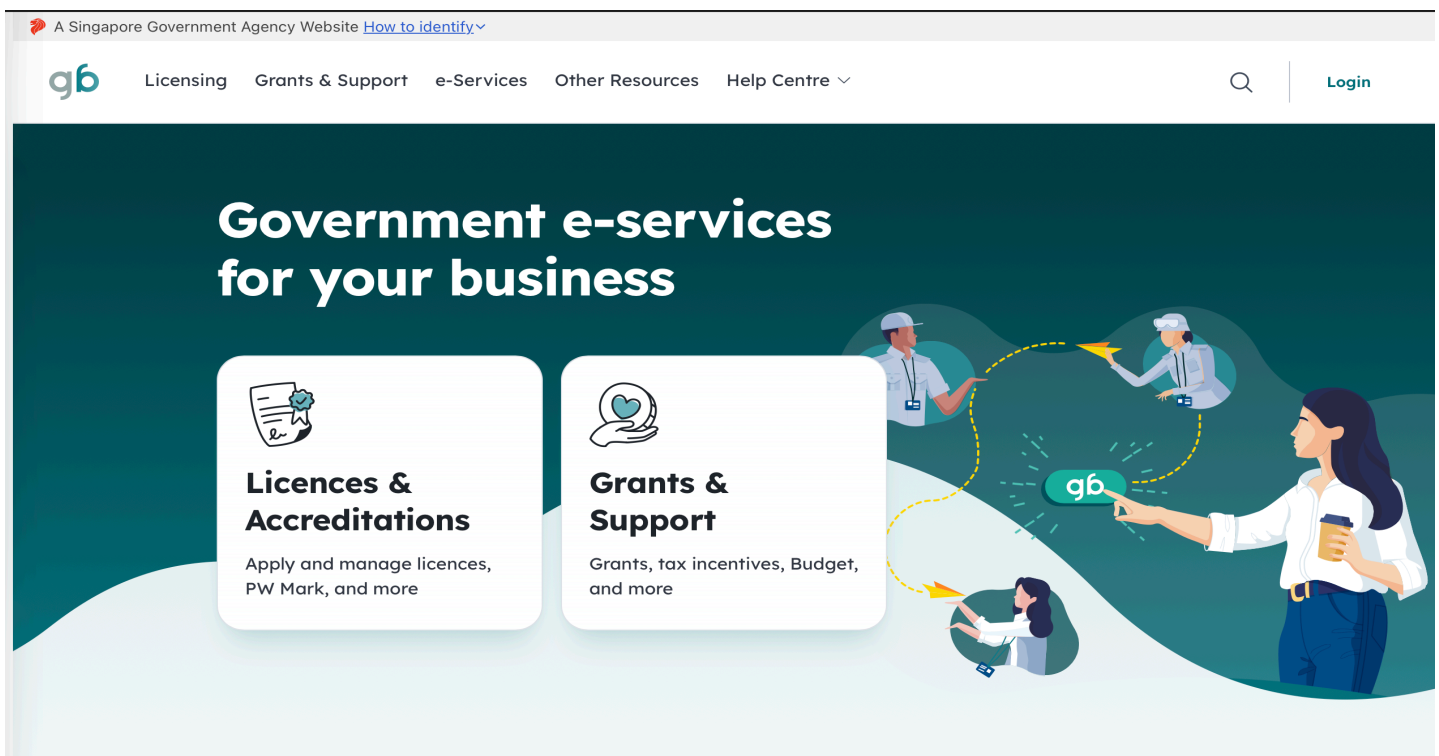


Figure 3 – (No dark mode option/preference available. Note: My system’s preference is dark mode).

Why it's a problem: The interface does not adapt to user-set preferences, forcing a high-brightness experience on the users who have explicitly chosen otherwise on their device, and it violates the *Accessibility and Inclusive Design heuristic* that interfaces should adopt to the user's preferences and needs and not override them.

Impact: Users who rely on dark mode for eye strain and light sensitivity or low vision reasons are disadvantaged. This disproportionately affects users working long hours or low-light environments.

Finding 3 → No language options – Major

Problem: The portal is available in English only. There are no language toggle options other than the browser translation tool anywhere on the homepage.

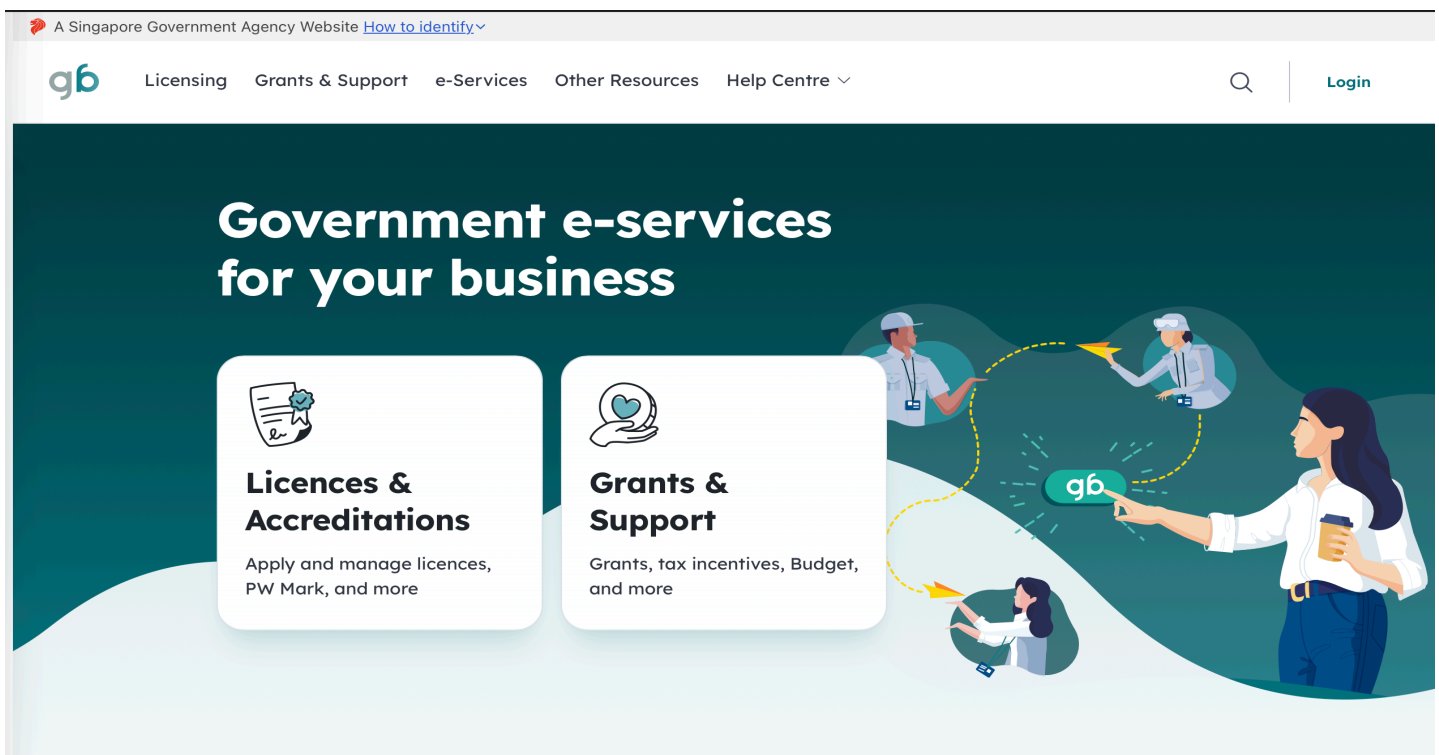


Figure 4 – (Homepage not having any language preference button accessible to the users).

Why it's a problem: This violates the *Accessibility and Inclusive Design Heuristic* – a government portal serving Singapore's multilingual population should not assume English proficiency. Language accessibility is not optional for a public-facing government service.

Impact: Business owners in industries like F&B, construction, and retail, where English may not be the primary working language, face higher cognitive load navigating regulatory requirements already written in formal and legal English.

Finding 4 → Chat Widget Resize Option – Minor

Problem: The GoBiz chat widget is fixed in size and anchored to the bottom right corner of the screen. Users cannot resize, reposition or scale it to suit their working context.

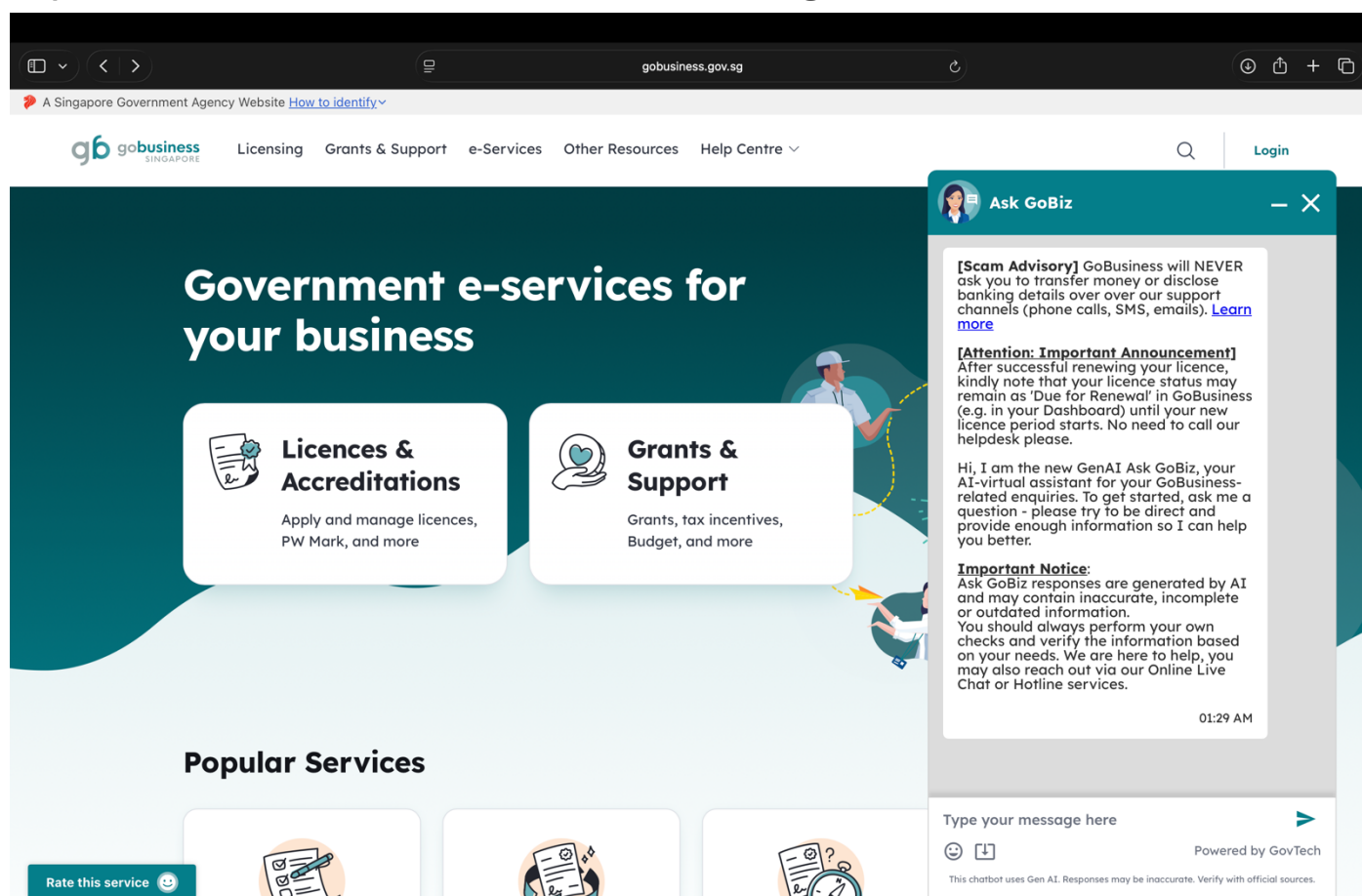


Figure 5 – (No resize option or ability for the chatbot option)

Why it's a problem: This violates the Flexibility and Efficiency heuristic, the interface should accommodate different users working in different ways. A fixed widget that cannot be moved or resized forces a one-size-fits-all interaction may obstruct content on the page behind it.

Impact: User referencing page content while filling a chat query, for example, checking a license number or reading a requirement are forced to close the widget to see the page, losing their focus from one screen to another in this process. A resizable, draggable widget lets users position it where it doesn't obstruct their workflow, making the support experience feel integrated rather interruptive.

Finding 5 → No Back Button on Login Page – Critical

Problem: When a user navigates to the GoBusiness login screen, there is no visible way to return to the previous page. The browser back button works, even that must be clicked more than once, but there is no in-interface affordance, leaving users who want to return

to the homepage or explore other options without an obvious path.

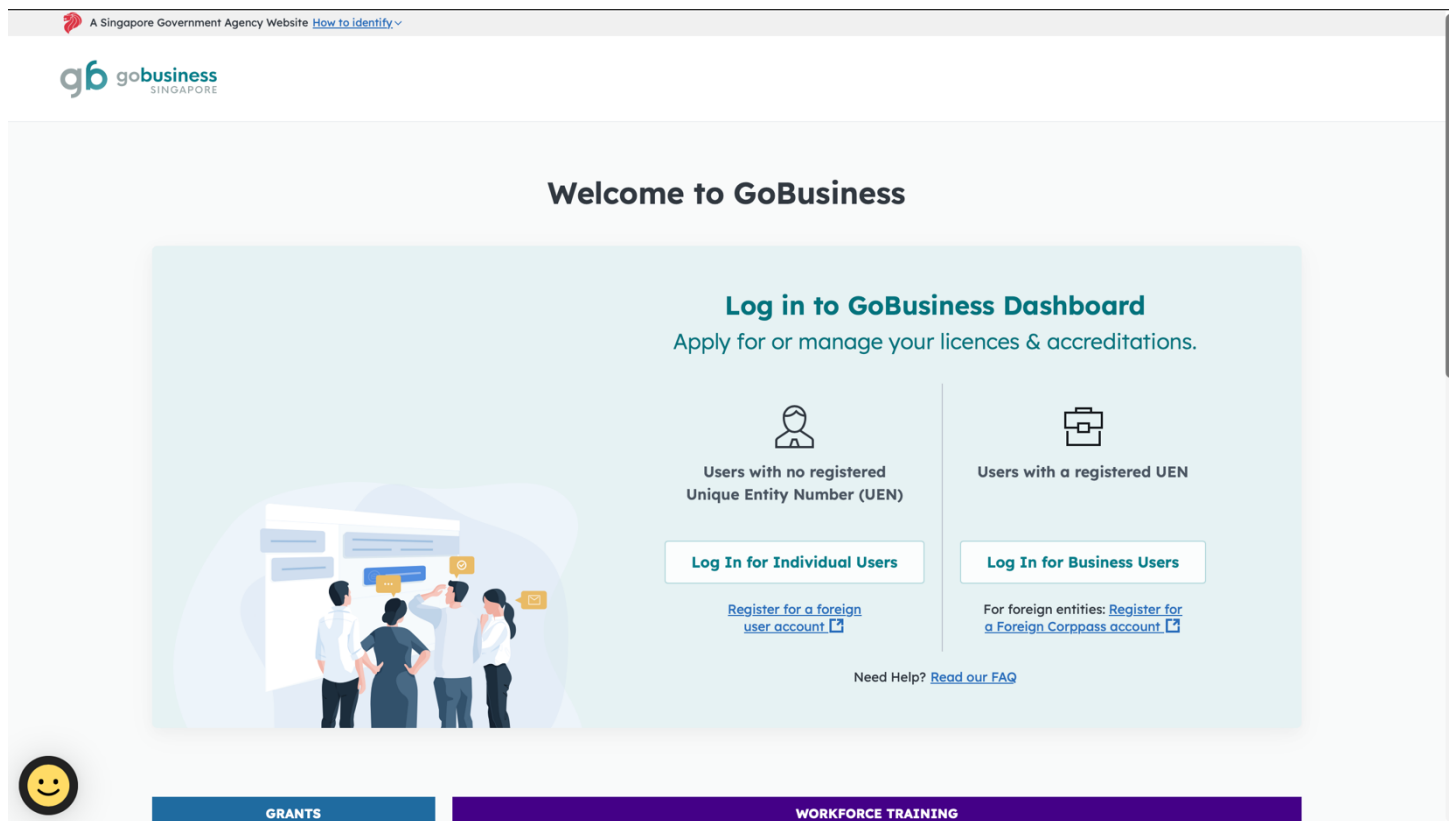


Figure 6 - (GoBusiness Login Page – No back navigation affordance visible).

Finding 6 → No Color Differentiation Between Sub-Topics and no alphabetical list – Minor

Problem: Within Categories like Licenses, all sub-topics are displayed with identical, visual treatment, same background, same text weight, no color coding, no text weight. Additionally, there is no alphabetical index at the start of the Licenses page inside the logged-in portal, forcing users to scroll through the full list to find a

specific licenser.

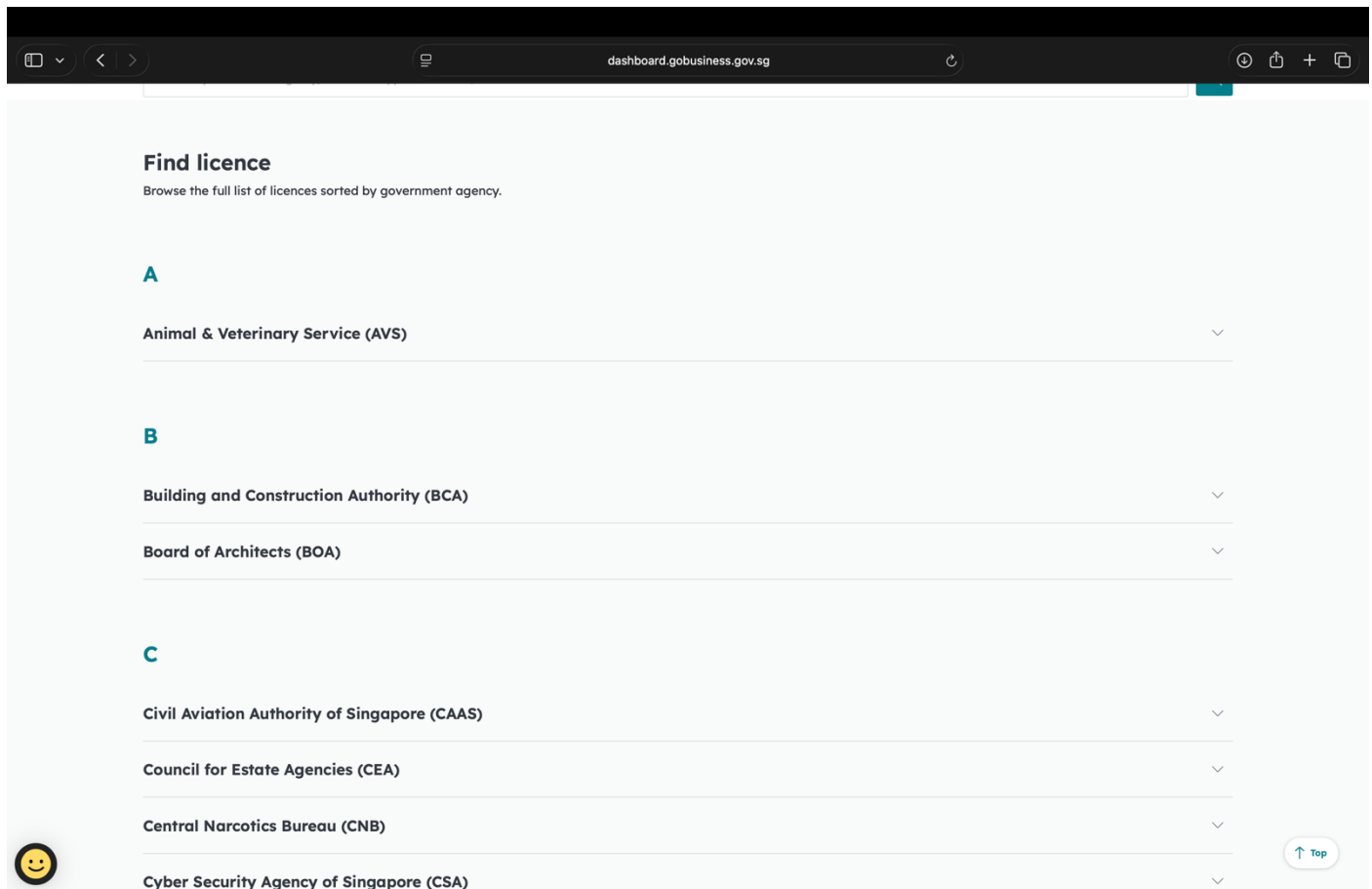


Figure 7 – (Alphabetical list exists – but no alphabet-based search or list/shortcuts).

Why it's a problem: This violates the Aesthetic and Minimalistic Design heuristic, every visual element should carry meaning. When all items look identical, the interface fails to communicate hierarchy. It also violates Recognition over Recall, users with a specific license in mind should be able to jump directly to it rather than scanning the entire list every time.

Impact: Categories with 5 or more sub-topics become difficult to parse quickly. Users slow down, re-read and sometimes navigate to the wrong item. For the Licenses page specifically, the absence of an alphabetical index means a user who knows exactly what they are looking for say a food shop license, still must manually scan the full list rather than jumping straight to F. This is a simple, high-value fix that significantly reduces time on task for returning users.

Finding 7 → Dashboard Recommendations Lack Hover States, and Has No Dropdown Menus– Minor

Problem: The logged in dashboard has no hover interactions on cards, no personalized recommendations based on the user history, and the dashboard components have no dropdown or quick look option to quick scan on the actions to be done.

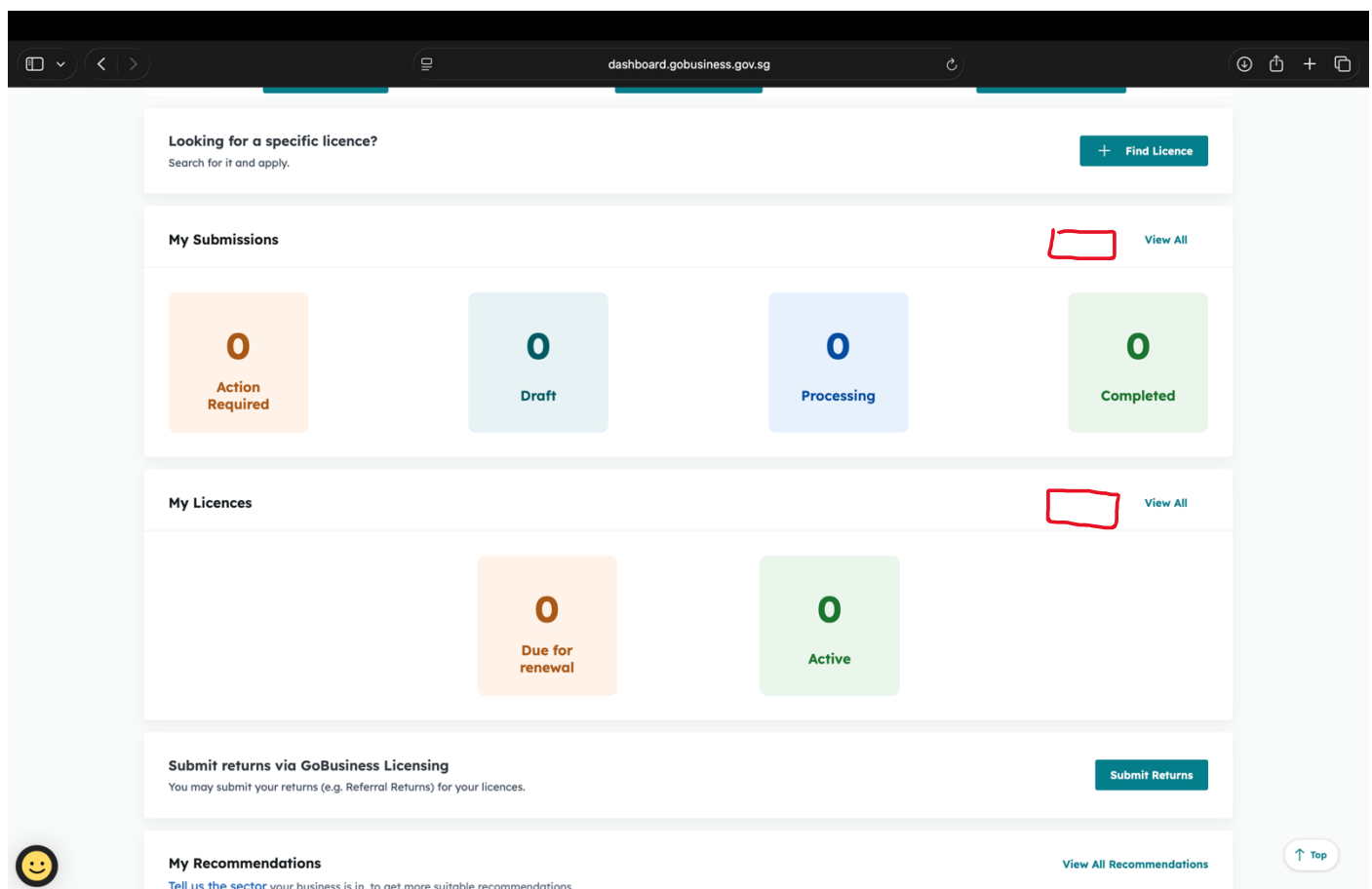


Figure 8 – (View all button available but no button for dropdown/quick look menu (red highlighted for implementation purposes).

Why it's a problem: These violations the Aesthetic and Minimalist Design heuristic, visual consistency is key to designers and the visibility of users. It also touches visibility of system status, the absence of hover states means interface gives no feedback that elements are interactive, leaving users uncertain about what they can act on, and the dashboard only has the “view all” button that

leads to another page so it wastes usage time and the time spent to do a certain job on the age will be higher.

Impact: Users must actively hunt what to do for every visit and lack of hover states makes the interface feel unresponsive, and coming to the “view all” button leads user to another page to view all the licenses be it only 1 or many licenses. This reduces the user’s time to do a particular job while accessing other components of the dashboard.

Redesigned Changes

Redesign 1 → Dropdown Navigation (Finding 1)

What I Changed: Restructured the top navigation into grouped parent categories with hover triggered dropdowns revealing sub-items. Categories are organized around the business lifecycle. Start, Run, Grow, Support rather than agency or product structure behind each portal. A 200ms hover delay prevents accidental activation.

Why this works: Grouping by user mental model rather than backend architecture means business owner looking to renew a license goes to “Run” instinctively and maintain design consistency

throughout the page.

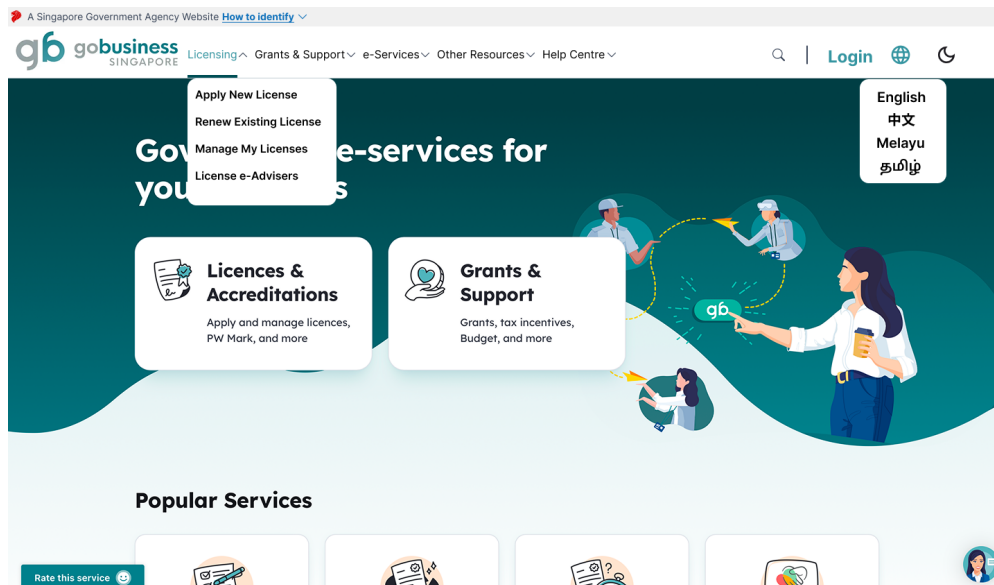


Figure 10 – (Redesigned homepage with dropdown navbar).

Redesign 2 → Dark Mode (Finding 2)

What I Changed: Added a system preference aware dark mode that activates automatically based on the user’s OS setting with a manual toggle in the top navigation for users who want to override it. The dark mode palette uses SGDS – compatible dark surface tokens, dark navy backgrounds with off white text maintaining brand consistency while meeting WCAG contrast standards in both methods.

Why this works: Respecting system preferences is now a baseline expectation across all digital products. The manual toggle in the nav also makes it discoverable for users who don’t rely on automatic system settings.

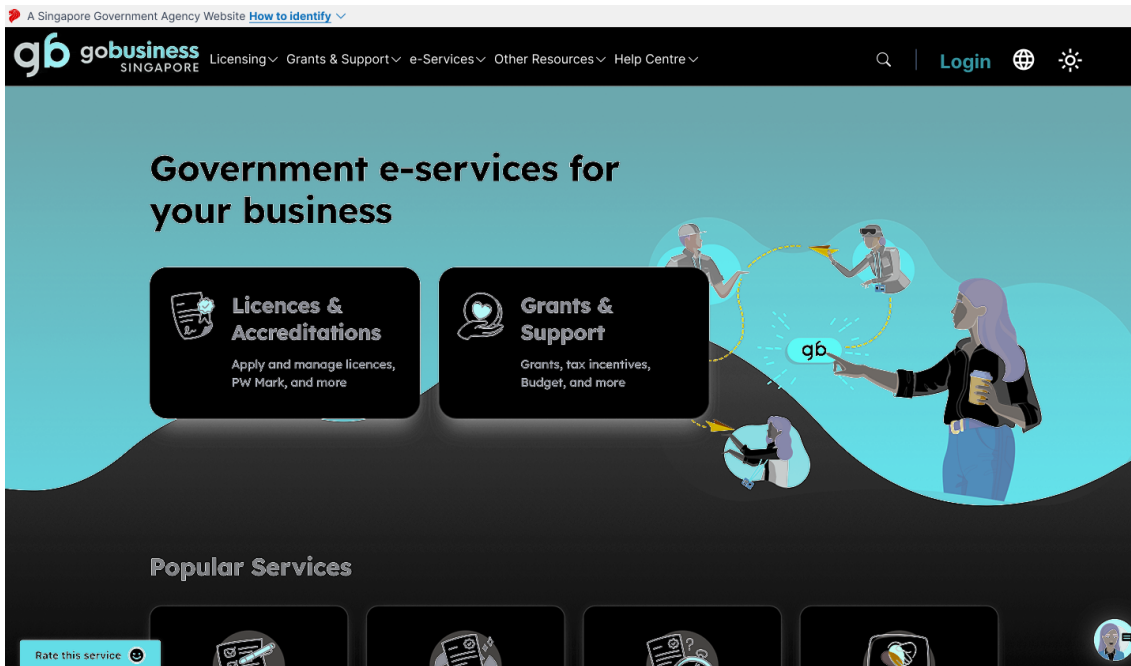


Figure 11 – (Redesigned homepage with dark mode colour scheme and accessibility option).

Redesign 3 → Language Selector (Finding 3)

What I Changed: Added a persistent language selector to the top navigation bar, accessible both pre and post login. Supported languages reflect Singapore's National languages English, Mandarin, Malay and Tamil. Once Selected, the preference applies across the full session and saves to the user's profile when logged in so they never have to reselect it.

Why this works: Placing the toggle in the top nav on every page means users never have to search for it. Saving the preference to

the logged-in profile removes friction on every return visit.

Other Resources ▾ Help Centre ▾

🔍 | [Login](#) 🌐 🌙



Figure 12 – (Zoom in picture of the language selector, clicking this will change the language of the website into the selected language).

Redesign 4 → Resizable and Draggable Chat Widget (Finding 4)

What I Changed: Made the GoBiz chat widget draggable and resizable. Users can click and drag the widget header to reposition it anywhere on the screen and drag the corner handles to scale it up or down. The widget snap-to-edge feature keeps it from being dragged off the screen partially.

Why this works: Users frequently need to reference page content while chatting, checking a license number, reading a requirement, filling a form field. A repositionable widget means the chat never gets in the way of the content the user needs to answer the chat's

own questions. Snap-to-edge prevents the widget from being accidentally lost off screen.

Redesign 5 → Back Button on Login Page (Finding 5)

What I Changed: Added a clearly labelled “Back” text button followed by the back button icon standardized for all navigation conventions at the top right and made the logo led to the home screen of the website alternatively. The link returns to the user to the homepage without clearing any form state they may have partially filled.

Why this works: A single small addition removes a significant moment of user anxiety. It also reinforces trust; the interface is not trying to trap users into logging in before they are ready.

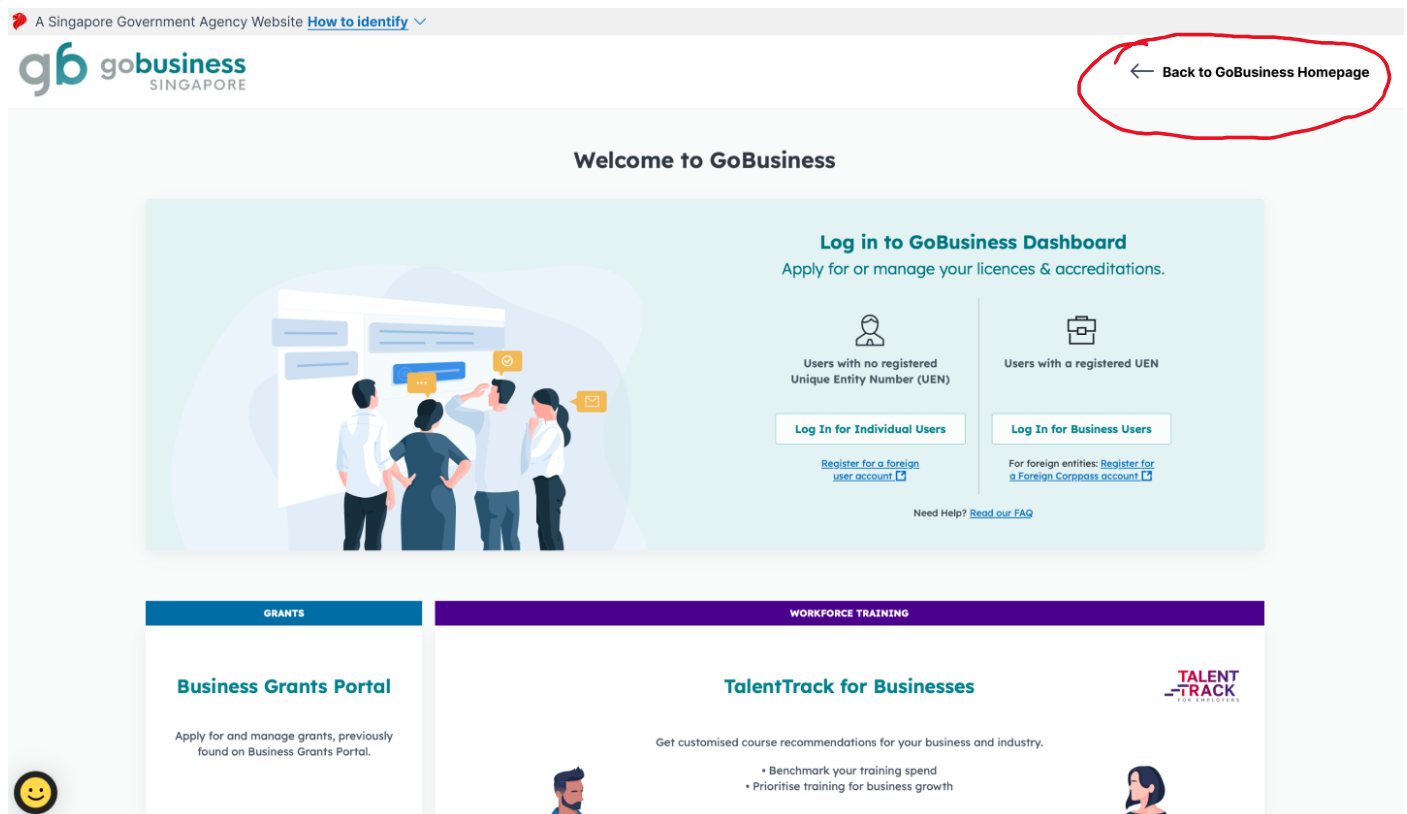


Figure 13 – (Redesigned login page with clear and concise back button, highlighted in red).

Redesign 6 → Color Backing for Subtopics and Alphabetical Index (Finding 6)

What I Changed: Introduced a subtle background color system to visually distinguish sub-topic groupings within each category. For the Licences page specifically, I added an alphabetical index bar and a search bar at the top – a row of letters for (A-Z) and a search bar that anchors to the corresponding section on click, letting users jump directly to the license they need.

Why this works: Color differentiates hierarchy faster than text formatting alone. The alphabetical index bar and the search bar at the top addresses a specific user behavior, someone who already knows the name of the license they need to scroll through the full list to find it. Together these 3 changes make both browsing and targeted searching faster.

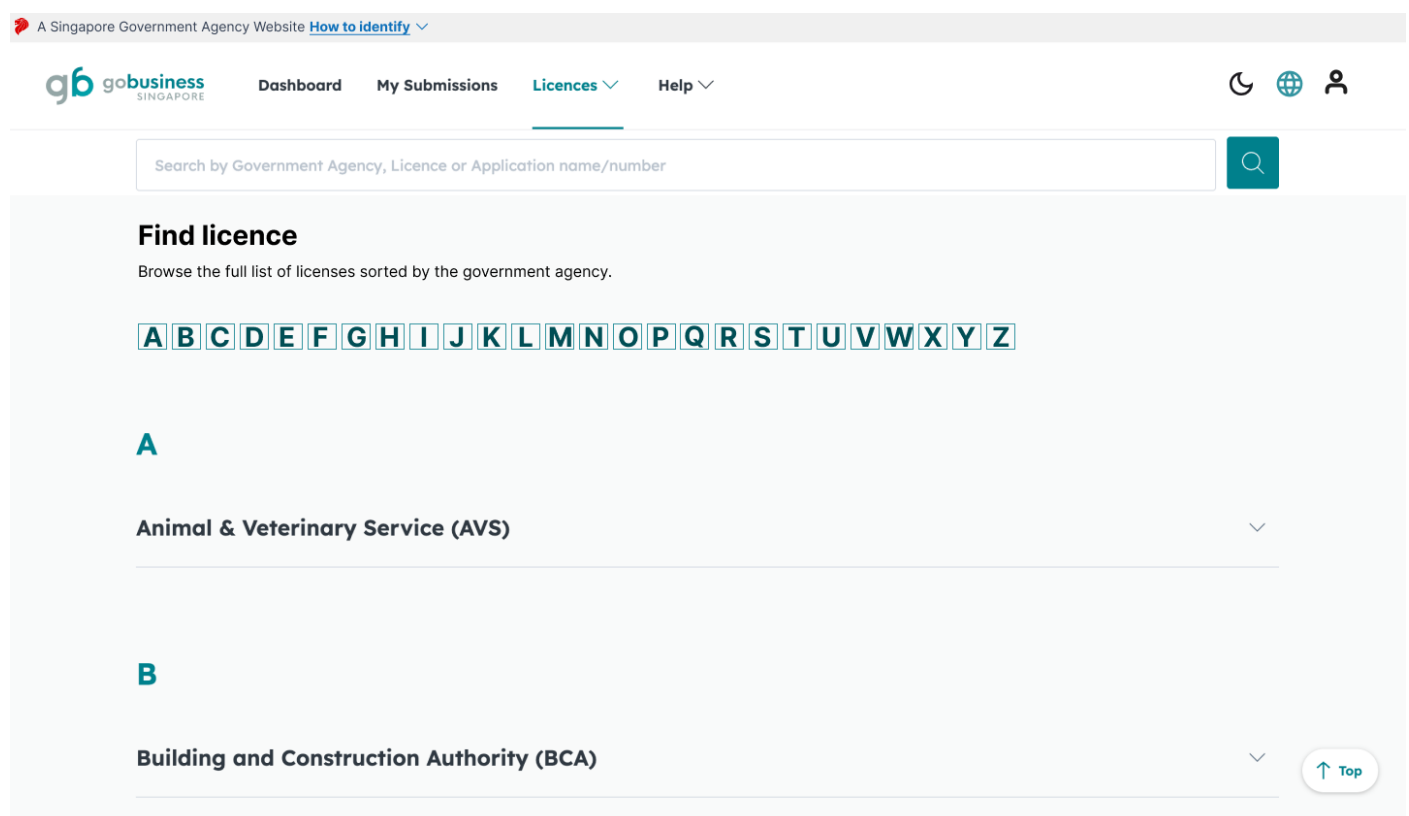


Figure 14 – (Redesigned find licence page with alphabetical index).

Redesign 7 → Dashboard Interactivity and Quick Scan Options (Finding 7)

What I Changed: Added three specific improvements to the logged-in dashboard. First, all interactive cards now have a visible hover state, a subtle elevation shadow and border color shift — making it clear what is clickable. Second, each dashboard component now has a dropdown chevron that expands an inline quick-look panel showing the most relevant pending actions without navigating away from the dashboard. Third, I added a personalized recommendations strip below the main dashboard header that surfaces upcoming renewals, incomplete applications, and relevant guides based on the user's license profile and activity history.

Why this works: The quick-look dropdown means users can scan all pending actions from the dashboard in seconds rather than clicking into each component individually. The recommendations strip turns a passive overview into an active task surface. The dashboard tells users what to do next instead of waiting for them to figure it out.

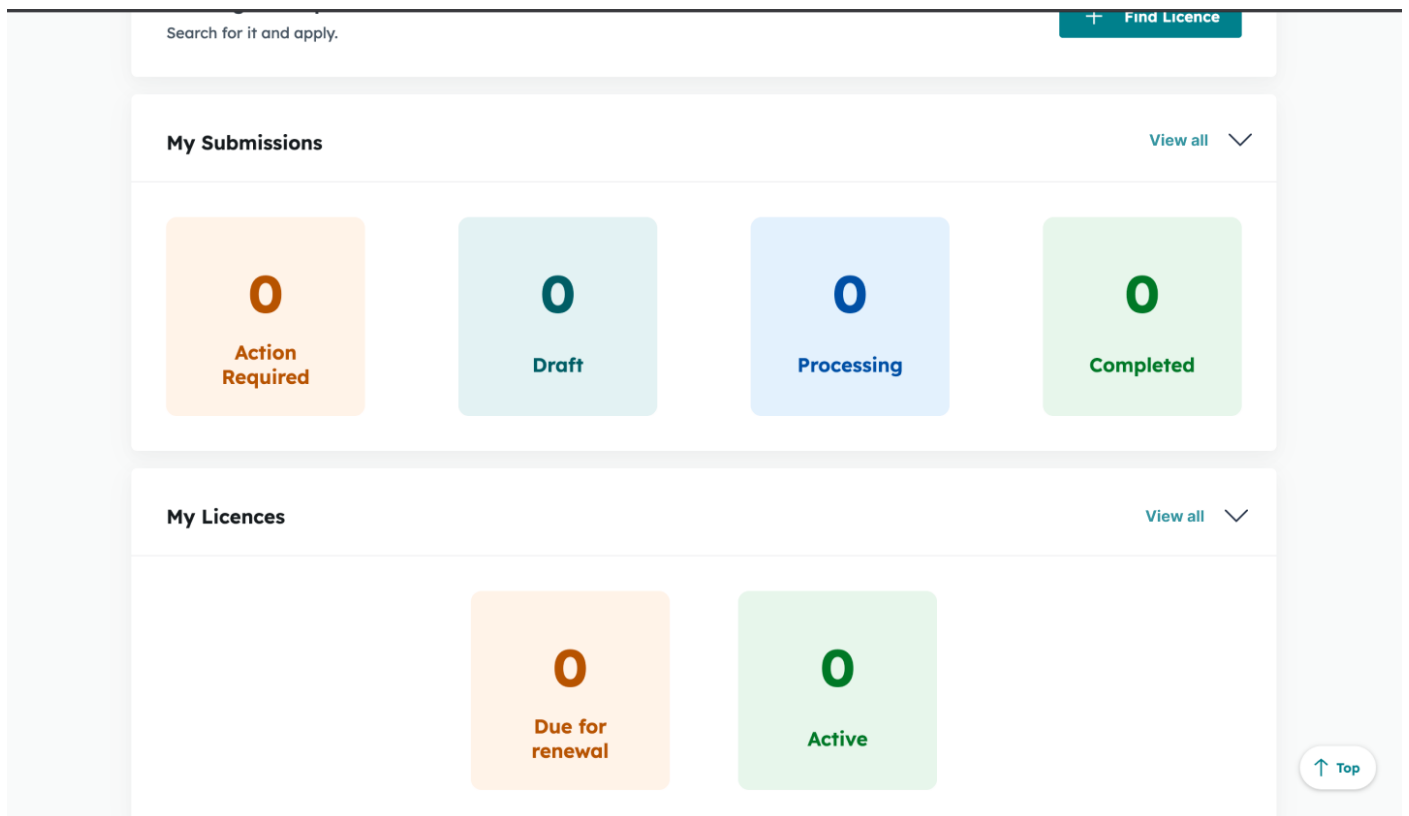


Figure 15 – (Redesigned dashboard with dropdown menu and quick look option, see fig 15b for reference).

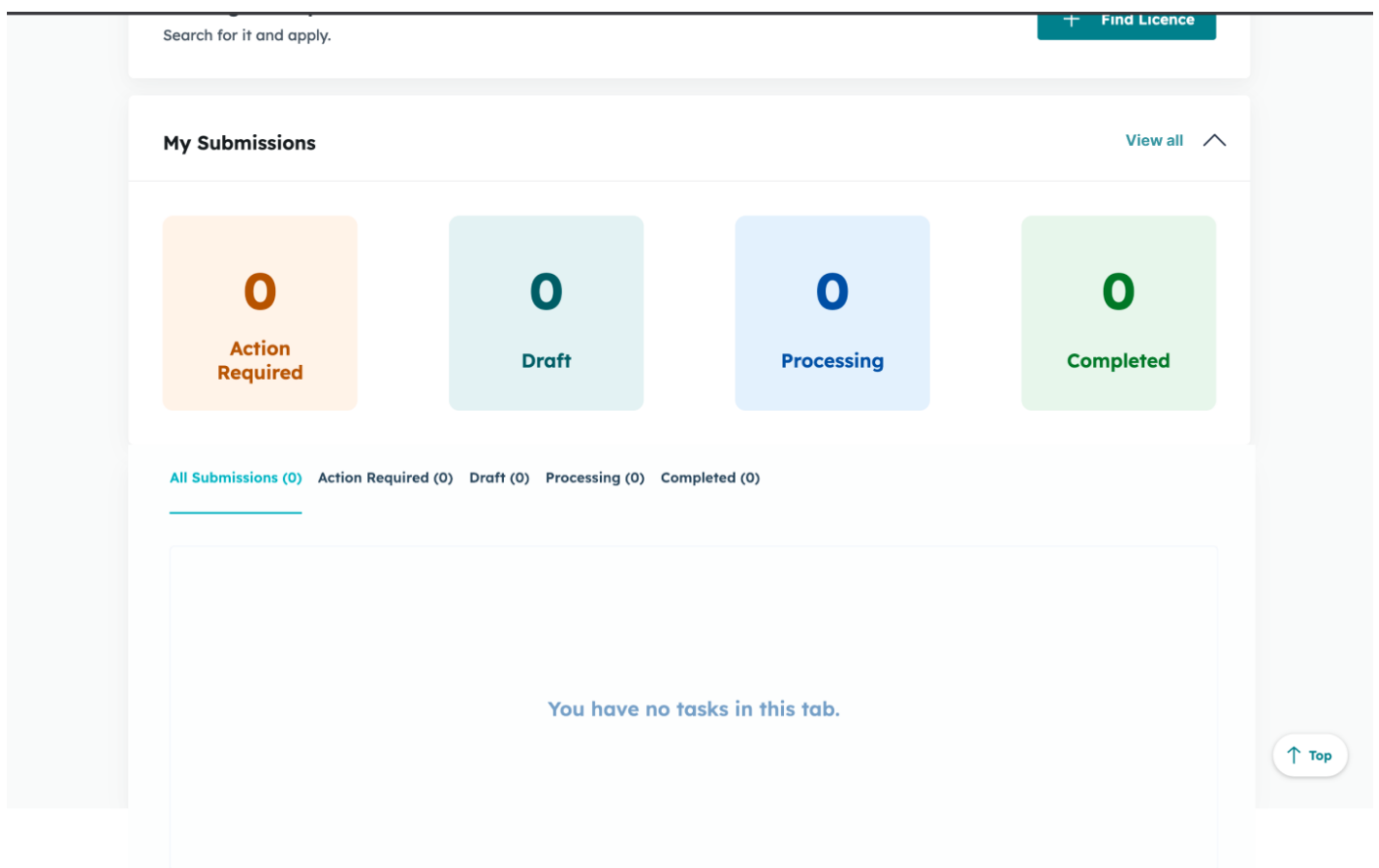


Figure 15B – (Dropdown menu and quick look extension).

Bonus Redesign — Personalized Homepage

What I changed: The GoBusiness homepage currently shows identical content to every visitor regardless of who they are or why they are there. I redesigned the logged-in homepage to adapt based on user profile — business type, industry, license history, and past activity. A returning F&B sole proprietor sees their upcoming renewal deadlines, F&B-relevant guides, and recently used services front and center. A first-time corporate applicant sees a getting-started checklist and guided journey tools. The personalization logic is based on the user's registered business profile, requiring no additional input from the user.

Why this works: A homepage that speaks directly to who you are and what you are likely there to do eliminates the orientation step that currently starts every session. This is especially high value for infrequent users. Instead of re-learning the portal each visit, the portal meets them where they are. Personalization based on existing profile data also requires no extra friction from the user, it is invisible and immediate.

Government e-services for your business



Licences & Accreditations

Apply and manage licences, PW Mark, and more



Grants & Support

Grants, tax incentives, Budget, and more



Popular Services

Rate this service 😊



Government e-services for your business



Licences & Accreditations

Apply and manage licences, PW Mark, and more



e-Adviser for Starting a Business

Use this e-Adviser for step by step guidance on starting and registering a business.



Popular Services

Rate this service 😊



Figure 16 – (Redesigned homepage with personalised menu and optins based on category of users).

What I'd Test Next

Hypothesis 1 — Navigation Dropdowns (F1) I believe grouping navigation into lifecycle-based categories with hover dropdowns will reduce the time it takes users to locate the correct section. I would validate this by running a moderated usability test — giving 5 business owners a task ("find where to renew your licence") on the current vs redesigned navigation and comparing time-on-task and error rate.

Hypothesis 2 — Language Selector (F3) I believe adding a persistent language selector will increase task completion rates among non-English speaking business owners. I would validate this by recruiting 3–5 Mandarin or Malay-speaking participants and observing whether the language toggle is discoverable without prompting, and whether translated content meaningfully reduces confusion during a licence application task.

Hypothesis 3 — Dashboard Quick-Look Dropdown (F7) I believe the quick-look dropdown on dashboard cards will reduce the number of page navigations required per session. I would validate this by comparing click-path data between the current "View All" flow and the redesigned dropdown — tracking how many clicks it takes a user to identify their most urgent pending action.

External Links

[Figma Link](#)

[Portfolio](#)

Conclusion

GoBusiness serves as a critical touchpoint between Singapore's businesses and the government agencies that regulate them. With over 6 million transactions facilitated to date, the stakes of getting the experience right are significant — every friction point in the portal translates directly to lost time for business owners navigating an already complex regulatory landscape.

This audit identified 7 usability findings across navigation, accessibility, information architecture, and dashboard interactivity. The redesign concepts presented here are not cosmetic fixes — each one is grounded in a specific heuristic violation and tied to a measurable user impact. The goal throughout was to reduce the cognitive load on the user: fewer clicks to find what they need, clearer feedback at every step, and an interface that respects the diversity of the people using it.

The most significant opportunity identified is the shift from a generic, one-size-fits-all portal to a personalized experience that adapts to who the user is and what they are likely there to do. For a platform serving everyone from sole proprietors to large contractors, treating every user identically is a missed opportunity to make every session faster and more relevant.

If given the chance to take this further, the immediate next step would be validating these findings with real GoBusiness users — particularly small business owners and contractors who interact with the portal infrequently and under time pressure. Good design starts with observation, and the findings here are hypotheses until tested with the people they are meant to serve.

Thank you.